unpredictable environment. The call for greater efforts, even sacrifices, is coupled with renewed confidence in the imminent achievement of the "great rejuvenation" of the Chinese nation. Here is what Xi Jinping said in a recent article in the party journal *Qiu Shi*: 'Our party must be united to lead the people to face major challenges effectively, defend against major risks, overcome major barriers and resolve major contradictions. We must press on with great struggles under new historical characteristics.'

The repeated use of the word 'major' reflects the seriousness of these challenges. Xi claims that the country "has never been closer to achieving its great rejuvenation but the last mile will be full of perils and challenges". The inevitability of Chinese rejuvenation, as an idea, has now been tempered with a dose of unpredictability.

What about Chinese foreign policy after the congress? Former US secretary of state Henry Kissinger seems to think that after consolidating his leadership at the congress, Xi Jinping is likely to make some conciliatory moves towards the US, acknowledging that his bet on Russia's Putin has gone sour. While China may distance itself to some degree from Russia, it is unlikely to undertake a major shift towards the US. Xi's ideological preferences stand in the way. This is apparent from constant references to the danger from US-inspired "colour revolutions", which seek to undermine and subvert socialist countries through ideological contamination. Regime security has always been the priority for authoritarian states.

Against this background, one should not expect any change in China's India policy. A more assertive, even obdurate, Chinese posture towards India is likely after the congress, even if there are some tactical shifts dictated by the forthcoming G20 and SCO meetings, which will be chaired by India. ■

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SENA SPLIT

SYMBOLISM VERSUS REALITY

By Kiran D. Tare

The Shiv Sena is no more. Or at least has been sent into a limbo, for now. The Election Commission of India (EC) on Monday, October 10, sealed the split in the 56-year-old party with the allotment of two separate names to the warring factions led by Uddhav Thackeray and Eknath Shinde. With it, the poll panel—as an interim measure—denied both of them the right to be the "real" Shiv Sena. The row had started with Shinde's coup in June that toppled the Uddhav-led Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi government and saw the rebel-in-chief become the chief minister in a stunning last-minute decision by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Now, while the Uddhav faction will be known as Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) with a '*mashaal*' ('flaming torch') as its symbol, the Shinde camp has been allotted the



LOST LEGACY? CM Eknath Shinde holding a 'bow and arrow', the Shiv Sena's old poll symbol

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